‘Sir, I came here with a request to stop this violence and all militant activities in India. Innocents are dying. I also want to tell you that Pakistan is not your friend. They are using you as a weapon to bleed our country/ Mathur said softly but firmly.

The conversation continued for more than half an hour. Chohan boasted to Mathur about the support for Khalistan from more than twenty lakh Sikhs settled in countries like the UK, the USA and Canada. These internationally-located pro-Khalistan groups, he said, managed to maintain close contacts with militant cadres in India. Sikhs in the USA, Thailand and West Germany had also set up financial hubs and safe houses to continue the operation till the goal was achieved, he said.

‘We already have a republic of Khalistan abroad and not just one organisation but hundreds are working together/ said Chohan. ‘Here in Washington we have a strong network working closely with the US government to achieve an independent Sikh state. And don’t forget, I am capable of launching attacks anywhere in India from right here in this house. Don’t forget what we did in 1986 against the policeman who tried to counter us.’

For a moment, Mathur was puzzled, but he quickly remembered the assassination attempt on Punjab’s director general of police, Julio Ribeiro, in which serving policemen were alleged to have been involved. They had been brainwashed, recruited and trained to penetrate a highly secure police compound to carry out the attack. Ribeiro survived but the event made headlines worldwide. Pro-Khalis-tan groups based abroad wasted no time to use the attack as a propaganda tool to generate more funds and cannon fodder for the militants.

‘Things are changing, Chohan sahib. Please give peace a chance,’ Mathur said.